

Citrus limon (Rutaceae)

Lemon

Lemon is one of the most important and versatile natural medicines for home use. A familiar food as well as a remedy, it has a high vitamin C content that helps improve resistance to infection, making it valuable for colds and flu. It is taken as a preventative for many conditions, including stomach infections, circulatory problems, and arteriosclerosis (thickening of the arterial walls).



Lemons were a remedy for scurvy (caused by lack of vitamin C) long before vitamin C was identified.

Habitat & Cultivation

Thought to be native to India, lemon trees were first grown in Europe in the 2nd century CE and are now cultivated in Mediterranean and subtropical climates worldwide. Propagated from seed in spring, they prefer well-drained soil and plenty of sun. The fruit is harvested in winter when the vitamin C content is at its highest.

Key Constituents

- Volatile oil (about 2.5% of the peel), limonene (up to 70%), alpha-terpinene, alpha-pinene, beta-pinene, citral
- Coumarins
- Bioflavonoids
- Vitamins A, B₁, B₂, B₃, and C (40–50 mg per 100 g of fruit)
- Mucilage

Key Actions

- Antiseptic
- Antirheumatic
- Antibacterial
- Antioxidant
- Reduces fever

Traditional & Current Uses

- **Valuable medicine** Spanish popular medicine ascribes so many medicinal uses to lemon that whole books have been written about it.
- **Established properties** Despite its acid content, once digested, lemon has an alkaline effect within the body, making it useful in rheumatic conditions where acidity is a contributory factor. The volatile oil is antiseptic and antibacterial. The bioflavonoids are antioxidant and strengthen the inner lining of blood vessels, especially veins and capillaries, and help counter varicose veins and easy bruising.
- **Preventative** Lemon is a valuable preventative medicine. Its antiseptic and cleansing actions make it useful for those prone to arteriosclerosis, and to infections and fevers (especially of the stomach, liver, and intestines). Its ability to strengthen blood vessel walls helps prevent circulatory disorders and bleeding gums. Lemon is also useful as a general tonic for many chronic illnesses. Above all, it is a food that helps maintain general good health.
- **Strengthening vein walls** The whole fruit, especially the pith, treats arteriosclerosis, weak capillaries, and varicose veins.
- **Juice** Lemon juice is good for colds, flu, and chest infections. It stimulates liver detoxification, improves the appetite, and helps ease stomach acidity, ulcers, arthritis, gout, and rheumatism. As a gargle, lemon juice is helpful for sore throats, gingivitis, and mouth ulcers.

**Lemon**

A small, evergreen tree growing to about 23 ft (7 m), with light green, toothed leaves.

Parts Used

Fruit and peel improve the circulation and increase resistance to infection.

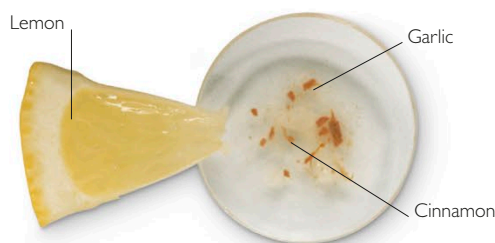
Fruit contains twice as much vitamin C as oranges



Pith and peel contain volatile oil and most of the bioflavonoids.

Key Preparations & Their Uses

Caution Do not take essential oil internally except under professional supervision.



Remedy For colds, combine 1 tbsp lemon juice with 2½ tbsp hot water, a crushed garlic clove, and a pinch of cinnamon. Drink up to 3 times a day.



Juice For sore throats, dilute 1 tbsp lemon juice with 1 tbsp hot water and use as a gargle.



Essential oil Dilute 5 drops with 1 tsp carrier oil. Dab onto mouth ulcers.

Externally, lemon juice can be applied directly to acne, athlete's foot, chilblains, insect stings, ringworm, sunburn, and warts.

Self-help Uses

- Acne & boils, p. 305.

- Arthritis, p. 313.
- Bites & stings, p. 303.
- Chilblains, p. 302.
- Colds & flu, p. 311.
- Cold sores, p. 304.
- Sore throats, p. 311.
- Weak digestion, p. 306.